

portion have now left or are about to leave. Sun has also a great website with a lot of information about MySQL, and is the main source for the MySQL source code and binaries."

This sort of praise for Sun is surprising, coming from someone who once wrote on his blog, "The main reason for leaving was that I am not satisfied with the way the MySQL server has been developed... In particular, I would have liked to see the server development moved to a true open development environment that would encourage outside participation and

without any need of differentiation on the source code. Sun has been considering opening up the server development, but the pace has been too slow."

But things have changed now, or rather those at the helm have changed. MySQL now belongs to a company that is the world's largest database vendor. Will things change for the good? "Not really," believes Axmark, "Since the suffering was mostly from being integrated in a big company. And this means another integration."

Another factor that will decide the

fate of the popular open source database is what MySQL means to Oracle—is it perceived as a threat or a benefit? Axmark thinks that MySQL is both a threat as well as a benefit. "But mostly a complement, since Oracle is not that big in the online/Web market. Oracle is aimed at OLTP [online transaction processing], and MySQL at Web-related stuff."

Monty agrees, "MySQL is more suitable for Web developers or for applications where the demands change rapidly. It's also more suitable for new applications where you want to quickly

failure of Open Source'

fits perfectly into the future of any company that wants to derive profit from technology investments!

Q Microsoft is Oracle's favourite rival. But Oracle now has more teeth. Operating systems, hardware, middleware, a complete range of databases, and the strongest MS Office contender—OpenOffice.org suite. Do you think Oracle will try to polish some of these apps to upset Microsoft Windows' market share among corporate users?

I see many possibilities, but I also think that Sun is a complex company. Acquisitions are complex, and I don't expect that Oracle is going to rush a strategy that it has one chance to execute correctly.

Q There is a school of thought that suggests that the failure of Sun and its buy-out by Oracle is a message that open source is not a profitable business model. What do you say?

I would say that Sun's failure is not the failure of open source, but more Sun's failure to work with open source properly. If you want to look at the profitability of the model, look at the company that's doing open source the best.

Q Oracle has been working with the Linux community, but is otherwise not seen as embracing the term 'open source'. How would the development of Sun's OSS products take place under a proprietary environment?

I do not believe in 'proprietary open source'. I also think that the many attempts to create hybrid open source models are doomed to fail. I believe that Sun's failure proved that, and I remember when people used to think that Sun was too big to fail. I believe that if Oracle attempts a hybrid

open source (or a 'proprietary open source model'), it will add its name to the list of companies who have failed by doing it wrong.

Q Do you think the open source teams from Sun will face a culture shock at Oracle, as the open source working environment seems to be missing at Oracle? The teams at Oracle may be more comfortable with Linux but not with Open Source?

Oracle has been contributing to the Linux kernel for quite some time, and they get no special treatment, good or bad, from that community. If you are talking about Sun's engineering teams now reporting to Oracle managers, I'm sure that differences in management/leadership style will be a shock for some and not for others. If anything, I would expect Java to fare a little better under Oracle than under Sun, in part because Sun treated Java like a child, and to Oracle it's just an asset. As I said earlier, I think that Open Source is a great way to grow the value of a technology asset, so perhaps Oracle will be more successful with a true open source strategy for Java than Sun—which for most of Java's lifetime, tried to make it look like it was open/open source.

